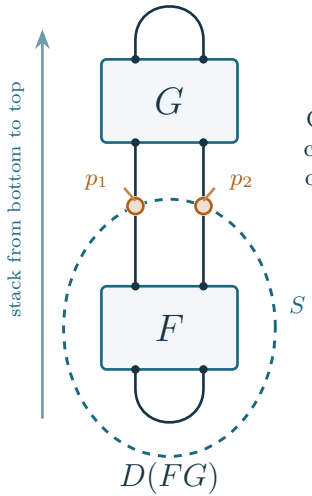
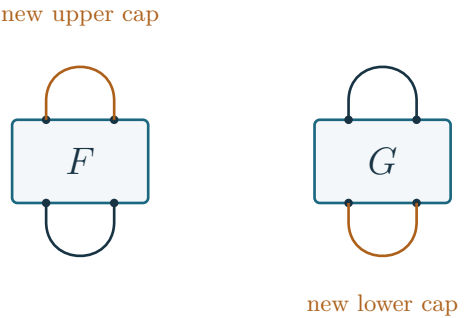
Splitting a cap-closed stack

The lower box is F and the upper box is G.



The sphere S encloses F and its lower cap. Its only link intersections are p_1, p_2.

Cut along S; cap each pair of punctures.



To reconstruct the stack, take the connected sum along the two amber cap arcs. Their components are the prescribed ones.

$$D(FG) = D(F) \# D(G)$$

The sphere meets the link twice. The amber caps specify the components used in the connected sum. For a link with several components, these choices are part of the construction.